West Indies, when Rooty joined me at the crease. We were 39–2 and facing an all too familiar obligation to build a score.

I might have looked calm and dispassionate to the casual spectator, but I felt an enormous weight of expectation, an insidious surge of pressure. That inner voice, a cold, caustic commentator on my faults and weaknesses, piled in on cue: 'Here we go again,' it said. 'Why are you putting yourself through this mental torture? You've got nothing else to prove.'

I went on to score 243. Joe made 136 and we won by an innings inside three days. But a pebble had been dislodged; an internal conversation with an inevitable conclusion was underway. This wasn't about anything as selfish as personal achievement; it was a private progression of truth and reconciliation. I had to be true to myself, and my teammates.

A player dealing with personal turmoil needs a coach who empathizes with his dilemma. Mark Ramprakash, England's batting coach, was the first person I turned to, as we walked back from a net session before our second warm-up match of that winter's Ashes tour, a day–nighter against a Cricket Australia XI at the Adelaide Oval.

Ramps was, by common consent, the most technically accomplished batsman of his generation. He was a driven character, an accumulator of 114 centuries, who retired with a first-class average of 53.14 a couple of months before his forty-third birthday. He fought against the dying of the light but understood where I was coming from.

'I don't know why I'm doing this any more,' I confessed. 'How many times do I have to dig to the well before there is nothing left?' That's a horrible phrase, a reflection of declining hope and increasing desperation. I was only thirty-two, theoretically years away from unarrestable decline, yet mental decay had set in.

Physically, I was fine, the fittest I had ever been. The ECB had looked after me exceptionally well, streamlining my schedule so that I had the occasional respite of a couple of months at home. A governing body of any sport has a corporate dimension, but behind the scenes it has good people on whom we rely as players.

Our families are hugely grateful to Medha Laud, whose liaison work has taken cricket out of the Dark Ages, the pre-Duncan Fletcher era in which tours were planned without thought for a player's personal life. This inevitably added to the strain on relationships, and caused quiet resentment.